Where AI Companion and Character Apps Are Going in 2027

By Garret Williams, Founder & CEO, Chatbrat.ai · October 27, 2026

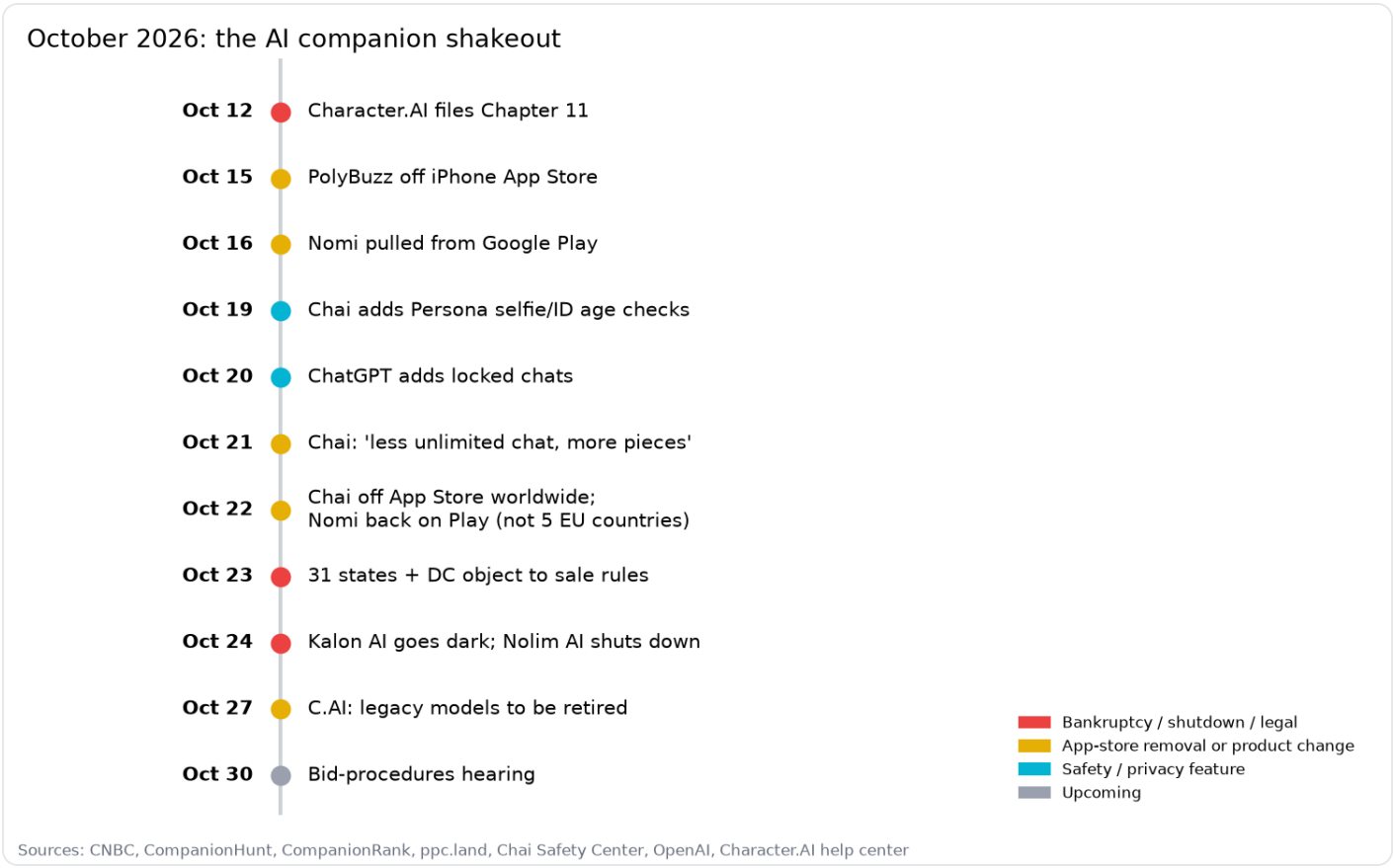
A data report on memory, safety, pricing and platform risk across 10 AI companion and character chat apps, built from October 2026 filings, help centers and trackers.

Key takeaways

- **Stability is now the deciding feature.** In October 2026, Character.AI entered Chapter 11, Chai and PolyBuzz lost their iPhone apps, Nomi was pulled from Google Play for six days, and two smaller companion apps went dark.
- **Memory is the main battleground, and most of it is paywalled.** The leading apps stack pinned notes, auto-extracted facts, rolling summaries and retrieval, but key layers at Character.AI, Kindroid and SpicyChat require a paid plan.
- **The next step for memory is human, not bigger.** Storing more facts is not the same as understanding a person. In 2027 the winners will remember context, meaning and relationships over time. That is Chatbrat's stated focus, which it calls **humanistic contextual memory**.
- **Safety is becoming mandatory.** 41 of 55 companion apps still check age with only a birthday field or checkbox (TechStory), while 41 state attorneys general are setting terms for any Character.AI buyer.
- **Real companionship beats sexting as a durable business.** The users regulators and reporters focused on this month were people afraid of losing a relationship, not a content filter.
- **Web-first is the safer foundation.** Every app-store removal this month left web versions running.

What happened to AI companion apps in October 2026?

October 2026 was the AI companion industry's shakeout month: one bankruptcy, three app-store removals, two shutdowns and a regulatory blueprint for the whole category.



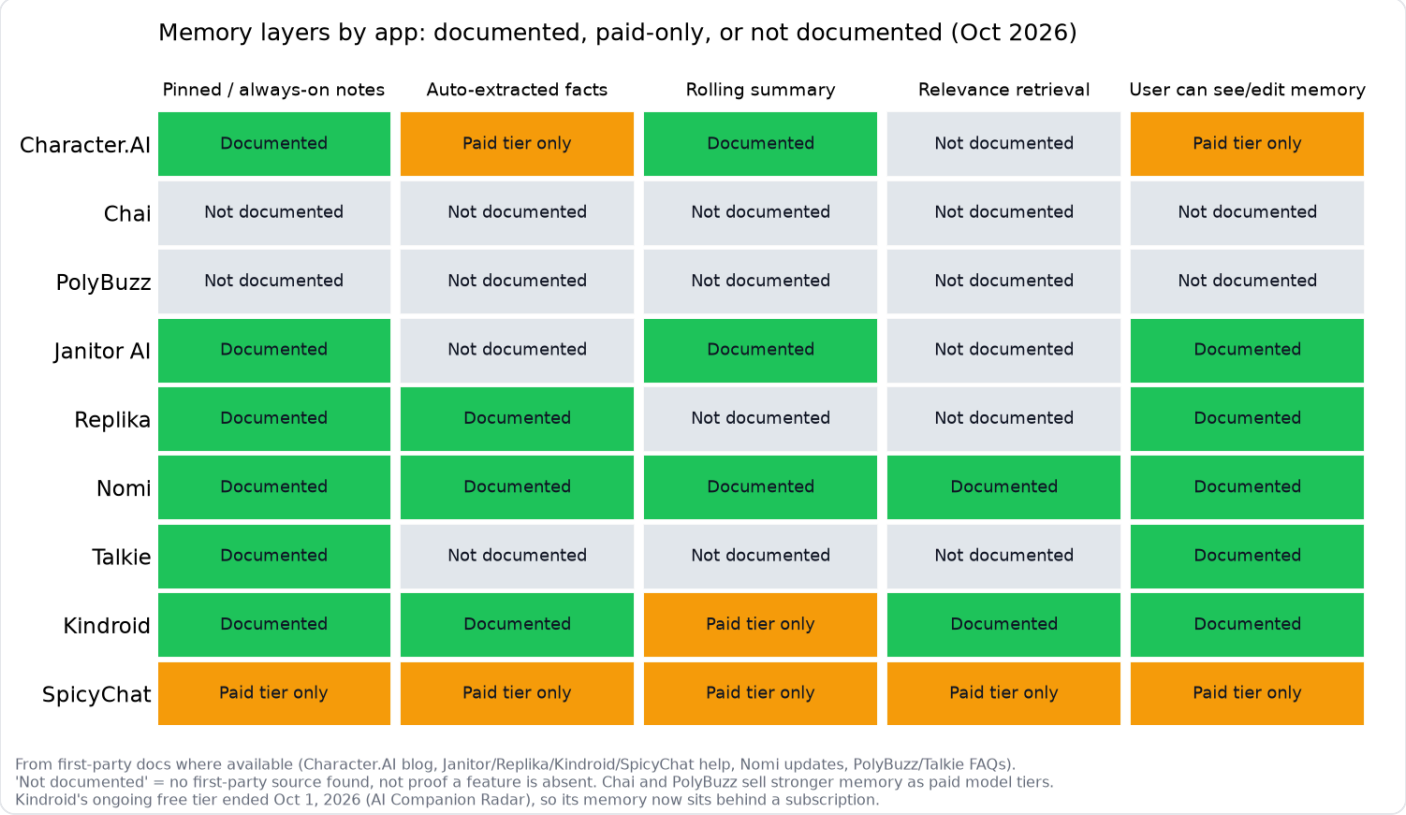
Timeline of October 2026 AI companion events

- **Character.AI filed for Chapter 11 on October 12.** Disney's opening $20 million bid licenses some IP but not the app or user data; if no buyer for the platform emerges by the November 20 bid deadline, the platform is wound down (CNBC).
- **Character.AI has about 12 million monthly users and loses up to $9 million a month**, according to the New York Post.
- **31 states plus DC objected to the sale rules on October 23**, arguing the $21.7 million minimum overbid blocks offers that would beat Disney's deal (ppc.land). The hearing is October 30 (AITried).
- **No consumer privacy ombudsman has been requested or appointed** to protect user data in the sale (Bankruptcy Observer).
- **PolyBuzz has been off the iPhone App Store since October 15** and dropped its $9.90 Basic plan (CompanionRank).
- **Chai's iPhone app was pulled worldwide on October 22**; Android and web still work (CompanionHunt). On October 21 its founder said Chai will offer "less unlimited chat experience, and more piece based experience" (CompanionHunt change log).

- **Nomi returned to Google Play on October 22 after six days**, but is still missing in Germany, France, Spain, Italy and the Netherlands (CompanionHunt change log).
- **Kalon AI turned off all features and Nolim AI shut down on October 24** (CompanionRank, CompanionHunt shutdown tracker).
- **Character.AI says legacy models PipSqueak 2 and Rawr will be retired "eventually"**, with notice but no date (Character.AI help center, AITried).

How do AI companion apps structure memory?

Every serious companion app now uses a memory stack, not a single memory: a character card, pinned notes, facts extracted automatically from chats, a rolling summary and retrieval of older messages. The difference between apps is which layers exist, whether users can see and fix them, and whether they are free.



Memory layers by app: documented, paid-only, or not documented

Memory layer	What it holds	Examples
Character card	Identity, backstory, example messages	Every app; Nomi Backstory, Kindroid backstory

Memory layer	What it holds	Examples
Pinned notes	Facts that must never drop out	Character.AI pins, Janitor AI Chat Memory, SpicyChat pins
Auto-extracted facts	Short facts about the user and characters	Character.AI Facts, Replika Memory, SpicyChat Semantic Memory
Rolling summary	The story so far, compressed	Kindroid Cascaded Memory, Janitor AI summaries
Retrieved long-term memory	Older moments pulled in by relevance	Kindroid long-term memory, ChatGPT chat history
Structured overview	People, places, goals and relationships	Nomi Mind Map

- **Kindroid shows which memories were recalled for each reply** and lets users deprioritize them (Kindroid help).
- **Nomi's Mind Map lets users view and edit what their companion knows**, while its Identity Core stays hidden (Nomi).
- **Character.AI added Story Memory and auto-captured Facts in May 2026, but Facts are c.ai+ only** (Character.AI blog).
- **SpicyChat's Memory Manager requires a paid tier** (SpicyChat docs).
- **PolyBuzz and Talkie say in their own FAQs that memory is technically limited** (PolyBuzz FAQ, Talkie FAQ).
- **Janitor AI redesigned "My Chats" in October 2026** with grouping, renaming, optional short summaries and bulk delete (Janitor AI changelog).

How do the top AI companion apps compare in 2026?

No single app leads on memory, safety, price and platform stability at once. The tables below compare ten apps as of October 27, 2026. "Not documented" means no first-party source was found, not that a feature is absent.

Memory and user controls

App	Documented memory layers	User memory controls	Memory behind paywall
Character.AI	Pins, Story Memory, auto Facts	Edit or disable Facts; usage meter	Facts and full meter (c.ai+)
Chai	Not officially documented	Not documented	Ultra marketed "5x better memory"
PolyBuzz	"Long Memory" / "Permanent Memory" model tiers	Not documented first-party	Stronger memory models
Janitor AI	Chat Memory field, optional AI summary	Full free-text editing, template	Larger context on janitor+ (unverified)
Replika	Memory tab, auto-captured facts, Diary	View, add, delete	Not documented
Nomi	Short/medium/long-term, Shared Notes, Identity Core, Mind Map	Edit Mind Map; Identity Core hidden	Longer backstory
Talkie	User-created Memories	Create, reset	Talkie+ "enhanced memory" (unverified)
Kindroid	Key memories, long-term, Cascaded, Learned Context, journals	Per-reply recall view, toggles	Cascaded Memory, Learned Context
SpicyChat	Semantic Memory 2.0, pinned memories	Add, edit, delete, pin (250 chars)	Memory Manager and Semantic Memory
Chatbrat	Persistent memory; stated focus on humanistic contextual memory	Memories stay the user's	Humanistic memory included free for signed-in users; planned paid plans add stronger models and more messages

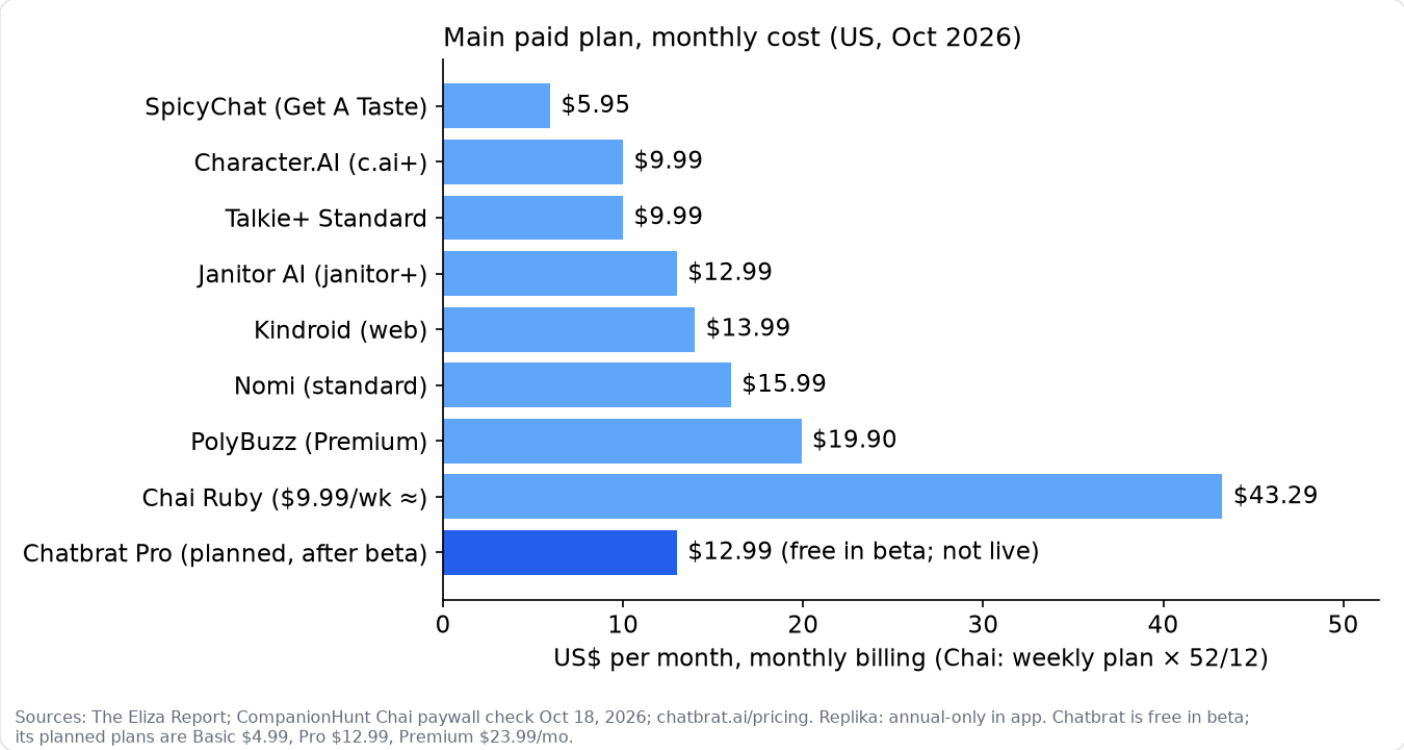
Price, platforms, age checks and content

App	Free tier	Main paid plan (US)	Platforms (Oct 27, 2026)	Age checks	Adult content
Character.AI	Yes, with ads	c.ai+ $9.99/mo	Web, iOS, Android	Age-estimation model worldwide,	Not allowed

App	Free tier	Main paid plan (US)	Platforms (Oct 27, 2026)	Age checks	Adult content
				then selfie or ID; open-ended chat closed to under-18s since Nov 2025	
Chai	Capped (pieces per message)	Ruby $9.99/week	Web, Android; iOS removed Oct 22	Persona selfie or ID; 18+	Adult text allowed; explicit images banned
PolyBuzz	Yes	Premium $19.90/mo	Web, Android; iOS off since Oct 15	Third-party check in UK; birthday elsewhere	Suggestive
Janitor AI	Yes, free core model	janitor+ $12.99/mo	Web, iOS, Android	k-ID in UK, Australia, Brazil; self-declared elsewhere	Allowed
Replika	Yes	Annual plans in app	Web, iOS, Android	Date of birth; no universal ID gate	Suggestive
Nomi	Limited	$15.99/mo	Web, iOS, Android; Play missing in 5 EU countries	Checks in Australia and Kansas; birthday elsewhere	Allowed
Talkie	Yes, with ads	Talkie+ $9.99/mo	Web, iOS, Android	Self-declared; minimum age 14	Suggestive
Kindroid	Free tier ended Oct 1, 2026 (preview only)	$13.99/mo on web	Web, iOS, Android	Behavioural estimation, then Yoti selfie or ID for flagged accounts, worldwide	Allowed for verified adults
SpicyChat	Yes	$5.95/mo entry	Web only	Video selfie or ID in FR, UK, IT, AU and 26 US states	Allowed

App	Free tier	Main paid plan (US)	Platforms (Oct 27, 2026)	Age checks	Adult content
Chatbrat	Free in beta: 50 messages a day as a guest, 200 per 24 hours with a free account	Planned after beta: Basic $4.99, Pro $12.99, Premium $23.99/mo (not live)	Web (any browser); app-store launch planned for early 2027	Click-through age confirmation	Playful and suggestive allowed; explicit or graphic NSFW not allowed

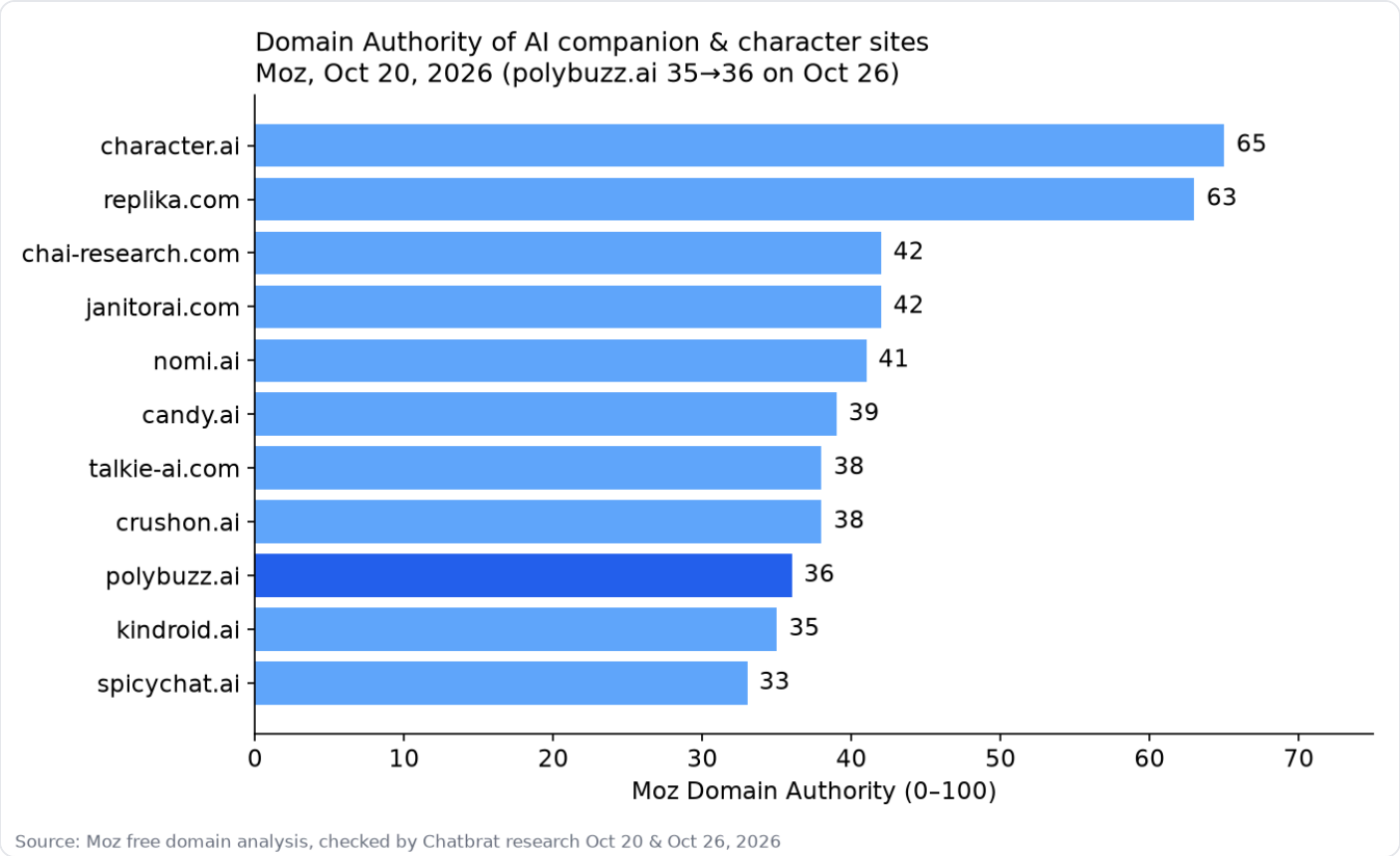
Sources: pricing and adult-content policy from The Eliza Report; Chai plans from CompanionHunt; age checks from AI Companion Radar and Chai Safety Center; Kindroid free-tier end from AI Companion Radar; Chatbrat beta limits and planned plans from chatbrat.ai/pricing; memory from each app's help center (linked above).



Main paid plan, monthly cost

Which AI companion sites have the most search authority?

Character.AI (65) and Replika (63) lead Moz Domain Authority by more than 20 points; the rest of the field sits between 33 and 42. PolyBuzz was the only site to move this month, from 35 to 36.



Domain Authority of AI companion sites

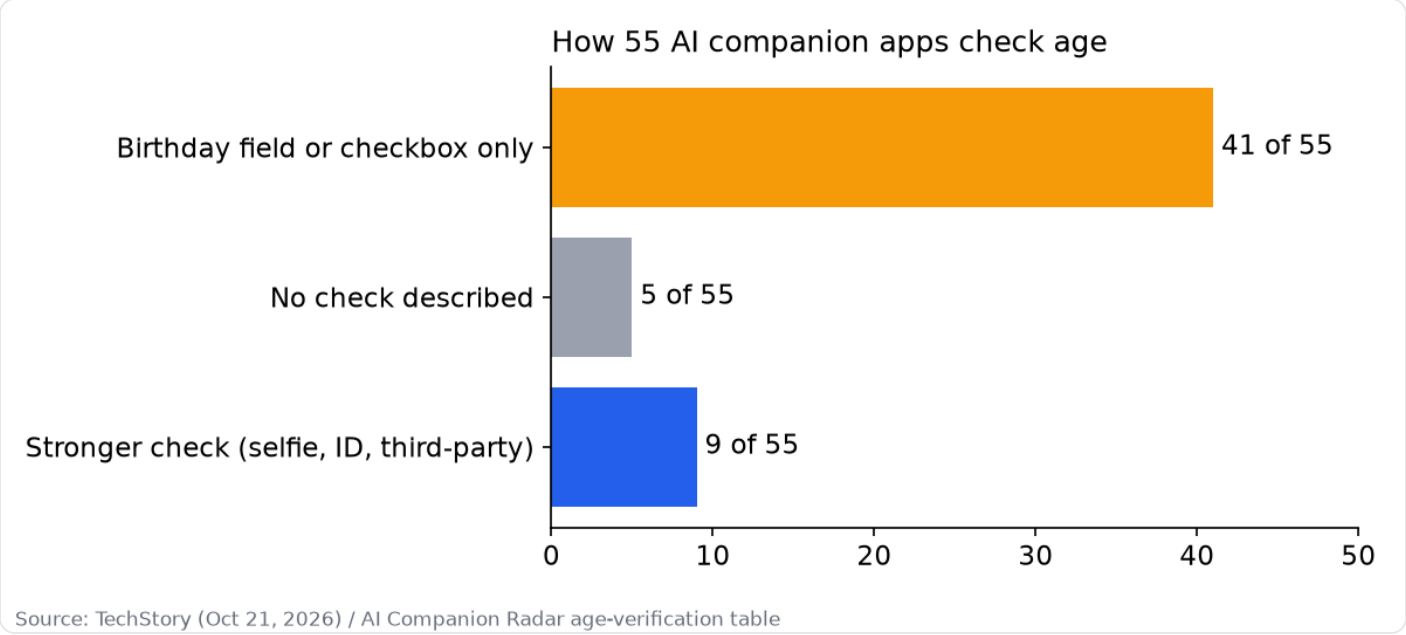
Domain	Moz DA (Oct 20, 2026)
character.ai	65
replika.com	63
chai-research.com	42
janitorai.com	42
nomi.ai	41
candy.ai	39
talkie-ai.com	38
crushon.ai	38
polybuzz.ai	36 (Oct 26)

Domain	Moz DA (Oct 20, 2026)
kindroid.ai	35
spicychat.ai	33

Source: Moz free domain analysis, checked October 20 and 26, 2026.

How strictly do AI companion apps check age?

Most don't: 41 of 55 AI companion apps verify age with only a typed birthday or a checkbox, five describe no check, and nine use selfies, ID or third-party verifiers (TechStory, AI Companion Radar). Only Character.AI, Kindroid and AiAllure apply stronger checks worldwide.



How 55 AI companion apps check age

The public wants more: 56% of adults surveyed by Common Sense Media said AI companions should require age verification (Common Sense Media).

Seven trends that will define AI companions in 2027

1. Stability becomes the headline feature

In 2027, users will choose companion apps on whether they will still exist next year. October's bankruptcy, delistings, shutdowns and model retirements showed that a companion relationship is only as durable as the platform under it.

2. Distribution goes web-first

Two major companion apps lost their iPhone listings in one month, and in every case the web version kept working. App stores still matter for reach, but a listing is a dependency, not a foundation. Products built web-first keep serving users on any device when a listing disappears, and can add store apps on top.

3. Memory shifts from fact storage to humanistic, contextual memory

The next memory race is about understanding, not capacity. Today's stacks store facts and summaries; the next step is memory that keeps context, meaning and relationships over time, the way a friend remembers you. Transparency is already table stakes at the top end: Kindroid shows what was recalled and Nomi lets you edit its Mind Map.

4. Safety becomes a baseline, not a feature

The expectations set for Character.AI's buyer are a preview for everyone: real age checks, no characters posing as therapists or doctors, crisis steps users can't click past, and consent before chats train AI (Troutman Pepper). Australia's eSafety regulator has already found gaps in age checks and crisis support at Chai (CompanionHunt timeline).

5. Real companionship outlasts sexting

The durable value in this category is the relationship, not explicit content. The users quoted in coverage of Character.AI's bankruptcy were afraid of losing a companion they had built over time (New York Post). Adult-first apps face the strictest age-check laws and app-store risk, while the largest platform, Character.AI, bans sexual content outright (The Eliza Report).

6. Users will own their memories and their data

Who owns your chats became a court question in 2026. No privacy ombudsman protects Character.AI users' data in its sale, and the states compared the case to 23andMe's bankruptcy, where California settled for $6 million (Troutman Pepper). Mainstream AI is moving the same way: ChatGPT added PIN-protected locked chats on October 20 (OpenAI).

7. Free, ad-supported chat proves it can scale

ChatGPT's ad business has reportedly passed a $1 billion annual run rate (Smillee). That points to a model where companion chat stays free to users while other apps narrow free tiers: Chai now charges per message and Kindroid ended its ongoing free tier.

Why is Chatbrat an up-and-coming AI companion platform for 2027?

Chatbrat is a web-first AI character chat and roleplay platform, free during beta, with persistent memory built around what it calls humanistic contextual memory: remembering people the way a person would, through context, meaning and relationships over time, not just stored facts. It runs in the browser today, with an app-store launch planned for early 2027, and users' memories stay theirs.

Here is how that lines up with the 2027 trends:

2027 trend	Where Chatbrat stands
Stability	Web-first: the browser version doesn't depend on any app-store listing
Web-first, apps next	Runs in any browser today; app-store launch planned for early 2027
Humanistic memory	Persistent memory, with humanistic contextual memory as its stated focus
User-owned memory	Memories stay the user's
Free access	Free during beta (200 messages per 24 hours with a free account), with humanistic memory included; planned paid plans from $4.99/mo add stronger models and more messages (pricing)

2027 trend	Where Chatbrat stands
Age confirmation	Click-through age confirmation, the same lightweight method most apps in the 55-app review use
Real companionship	Playful and suggestive content allowed; explicit or graphic NSFW content not allowed

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Frequently asked questions

Where are AI companion apps going in 2027?

AI companion apps are heading toward stability, web-first distribution, safer design and deeper memory. After October 2026's bankruptcy, app-store removals and shutdowns, users and regulators are rewarding platforms that stay available, verify age, protect data and remember users meaningfully.

What is humanistic contextual memory?

Humanistic contextual memory is Chatbrat's stated approach to AI memory: remembering a person the way another person would, through context, meaning and the relationship over time, rather than storing a list of raw facts.

How do AI companion apps remember conversations?

Most use a memory stack: a character card, pinned notes, facts extracted automatically from chats, a rolling summary and retrieval of older messages. Kindroid and Nomi expose the most to users; Chai, PolyBuzz and Talkie document the least.

Which AI companion apps are free in 2026?

Character.AI, Janitor AI, Replika, Talkie, SpicyChat and PolyBuzz have free tiers, and Chatbrat is free during beta (50 messages a day as a guest, 200 per 24 hours with a free account). Chai now charges pieces per message with a capped free allowance, and Kindroid ended its ongoing free tier on October 1, 2026.

Which AI companion apps verify users' age?

Only nine of 55 apps use selfies, ID or third-party verifiers, and only Character.AI, Kindroid and AiAllure do so worldwide. Janitor AI, SpicyChat and PolyBuzz verify only in certain countries; most others rely on a birthday field.

What happens to Character.AI chats in the bankruptcy?

It is not settled. Disney's bid licenses IP but not the app or user data, no privacy ombudsman has been appointed, and if no buyer takes the platform by November 20, it will be wound down. The bid-procedures hearing is October 30, 2026.

Why did Chai and PolyBuzz disappear from the iPhone App Store?

Neither company has publicly explained the removals. Chai's founder said the team is improving its Apple app and that installed copies still work. Both apps remain available on Android and the web.

What is Chatbrat?

Chatbrat is a web-first AI character chat and roleplay platform with persistent memory, free during beta, with an app-store launch planned for early 2027. Its stated focus is humanistic contextual memory, and users' memories stay theirs. It allows playful and suggestive content but not explicit or graphic NSFW content.

Sources

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